

maintenance and tune-up procedures. We even used Mobil One synthetic oil! The car had a good set of Michelin MXV4 tires with a few thousand miles on them. And, perhaps most important, we had purchased the car new. My classified ad outlined many of these characteristics.

Allow me to profile some of the characters who took the time to stop by and look over our car.

Shopper One: a senior marketing officer, female

She arrived driving an Infiniti Q45. When I saw the car, I asked her why she was interested in a Legend, since her Q45 appeared to be nearly new. She told me that the Q45 was her husband's and that they had purchased it used nearly a year ago. In fact, she had just finished looking over "previously owned" Legends and Infinitis at several dealers. She made it very clear that her household had a used-vehicle orientation. It was not particularly loyal to any make of automobile, but she and her husband did prefer a narrow set of vehicles. These included Acura Legends, Infiniti Q45s, and the Lexus 400 series.

The day she visited me, she had taken the afternoon off from work. She had a map of the Atlanta area and had marked the location of selected dealers and the addresses of private sellers. In this way, she made it very clear to me that she was well aware of many "compelling" opportunities.

It was obvious to me that this woman was very skilled in evaluating used cars. She immediately pointed to a small ding on the driver's door. She examined the interior, the engine compartment, and the car's sheet metal. Then she asked me why I had to sell the Legend. I responded by saying that "my teenage children have an aversion to four-door sedans. To them, a Legend is well suited for middle-aged, unexciting people like their parents! They would much prefer even a well-used 4x4 sports utility vehicle or a sporty two-door number."

She paused and reflected on my comments. Now that I think about it, I suspect she would have preferred another answer. She would have wanted me to say that I was selling the vehicle because of financial obligations. This would have put her in a much stronger bargaining position. Nonetheless, she attempted to negotiate a lower price. She asked, "What's the lowest you are willing to take for the car?" I responded by telling her, "If I don't sell it in thirty days, I will consider lowering the price." I then pointed to the portfolio in the front seat,